

Smriti Irani
Minister of Women & Child Development, Minority Affairs

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

WOMEN & CHILD DEVELOPMENT

No Child's Play

The government has taken several steps for the welfare of women and children, but the real challenges run deeper

By Sonali Acharjee

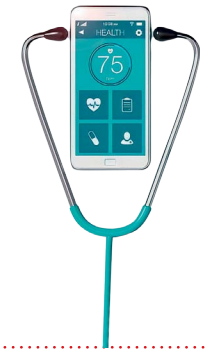
IT'S COMMON WISDOM THAT no society can advance until its women are empowered and contribute as equal partners in development—and India, to put it mildly, has plenty of room for improvement on that front. The work of the Women & Child Development (WCD) Ministry, thus, assumes deep significance in our national project. Last year, the ministry divided its major schemes into three categories: the Saksham Anganwadi & Poshan 2.0 for nutrition and education, Mission Shakti for the safety and empowerment of women, and Mission Vatsalya for child welfare. All three have notched up some valuable hash marks on a sheet still largely blank.

Under Saksham Anganwadi, the WCD ministry—led by Smriti Irani since last year—plans to upgrade the infrastructure at some 200,000 centres with smart learning facilities. As of December 2022, the government had distributed 1.1 million-odd smartphones and 1.2 million health monitoring devices among anganwadi workers. The Poshan Tracker app, launched in 2021, had onboarded over 98 million beneficiaries until last September. As of 2022, some 27.9 million pregnant and lactating mothers had received financial aid under the Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana. Over 730 one-stop centres have also been set up across India to provide aid to women facing violence.

But these steps seem modest when set against the journey left to be made. UNICEF data suggests that every year, nearly 1.5 million Indian girls get married before the legal age of 18. From 2017 to 2021, India counted a total of 35,493 dowry deaths. The latest NCRB report (2021) shows an alarming rise in the rate of crime against women (incidents per 1 lakh population): from 56.5 per cent in 2020 to 64.5 per cent. Crimes against children also spiked—2020 saw 128,000 cases, that rose 16 per cent to 149,000 in 2021. Not to speak of child and maternal nutrition markers that remain grim. That WCD got only a Rs 25,449 crore outlay in 2023—a tenth of what roads got—and that India's gender budget has dipped to 0.74 per cent of its GDP speaks of a need to reset priorities. ■

BOLD & BRAVE

98 MILLION
No. of beneficiaries onboarded on Poshan (nutrition) Tracker since 2021



1 MILLION
Health monitoring devices, smartphones distributed among anganwadi workers

BUT...

3.3 MILLION
Number of malnourished children in India: over half of them fall in the severely malnourished category